

Keiji Inafune: The Father of Mega Man

A Chronicle of a Visionary in Video Game Development

Born on 8 May 1965 in Osaka, Japan, Keiji Inafune would go on to become one of the most consequential figures in the history of interactive entertainment. After graduating from Osaka University of Arts, he joined Capcom in 1987 as an artist — a modest entry point for a career that would reshape the medium entirely.

His earliest and most enduring contribution arrived almost immediately: the character design for Mega Man (1987), the iconic Blue Bomber whose acrobatic precision and modular abilities became a blueprint for an entire genre of action-platformers. Although Inafune has clarified that the original concept was initiated by a colleague, his subsequent stewardship of the franchise across more than twenty titles cemented his authorship of the character's identity.

As Inafune's responsibilities expanded within Capcom, he assumed creative oversight on two of the company's most celebrated franchises. For Street Fighter II (1991), he contributed character artwork that helped define the visual language of competitive fighting games — work that proved critical at a moment when arcades worldwide were on the cusp of a cultural renaissance. A decade later, he served as producer on Resident Evil (Biohazard) and its sequels, guiding the survival-horror franchise through a period of remarkable commercial and critical success. Resident Evil 4 (2005), released under his supervision, is widely regarded as one of the finest action games ever made and is credited with redefining the third-person shooter genre.

By 2009, Inafune held the position of Global Head of Production at Capcom, overseeing development across the studio's entire portfolio. Yet, at the height of his institutional influence, he resigned in 2010, citing deep frustration with what he publicly described as a deteriorating culture of creativity within the Japanese games industry — remarks that sparked considerable debate throughout the sector.

Following his departure, Inafune founded Comcept and embarked on an ambitious crowdfunding campaign for Mighty No. 9 (2016), a spiritual successor to Mega Man. Despite raising approximately four million US dollars on Kickstarter — a record at the time — the project

attracted significant criticism upon release for failing to meet the elevated expectations of its backers. Undeterred, he continued to pursue independent development, and in 2022 co-founded Level Infinite in collaboration with international partners.

Keiji Inafune's legacy is one of paradox: a creator whose finest work redefined popular culture, whose institutional courage forced an industry-wide conversation about creative stagnation, and whose later ventures revealed the distance between vision and execution. His contributions to Street Fighter and Resident Evil alone would secure his place in the pantheon of game development — yet it is the Blue Bomber, leaping eternally across pixelated skies, that remains the most fitting emblem of his restless ambition.

